

Unpacking public animosity toward professional journalism: A qualitative analysis of the differences between media distrust and cynicism

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Abstract

Amidst a widely discussed crisis in audience-media relations, this study argues for the importance of a more nuanced understanding of audience animosity toward professional journalism. Based on 20 in-depth interviews with diverse news audiences in Serbia, we explored how media distrust and cynicism can be empirically distinguished. While both perceptions entail negative expectations from journalism, our findings indicate that they diverge with respect to interviewees' views on journalistic ideals and integrity, differentiation between media actors, and receptivity to journalistic performance. In the interviews, cynicism emerged as the deterministic and process-oriented perception that journalism serves no other purposes than financial profit and audience manipulation. In contrast, distrust was a more nuanced, probing, and outcome-oriented perception that may be open to correction in the presence of counter-evidence. These findings can help media researchers and educators to better diagnose and address negative media perceptions.

Keywords

media cynicism, media distrust, media perceptions, audience-media relationships

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For its 20th Anniversary Special Issue, *Journalism* asked some of the world's leading communication scholars to identify the biggest challenge facing journalism today (Tumber and Zelizer, 2019). Unsurprisingly, several scholars centered their responses around deteriorating public trust in the institution of professional journalism. For instance, Fenton (2019) discussed the decline in public trust as a response to journalistic practices that ever more frequently deviate from normative ideals. Sonwalkar (2019) attributed growing public distrust to the omnipresent "Murdochization" of journalism, a profession increasingly governed by business logic rather than by editorial principles. Robinson (2019) tied public distrust to the perceived tendency of the media to cozy up to the elite and lose ties with the public.

These and other similar accounts show a tendency to analyze the current crisis of audience-media relations primarily in terms of (dis)trust. Most definitions of media trust revolve around audience's expectations that the media will conform to professional and ethical journalistic norms (e.g., Ardévol-Abreu et al., 2018: 615–616; Peifer, 2018: 735; Tsfati and Cohen, 2005: 31). While media distrust is rarely explicitly defined (but see Tsfati and Cappella, 2003), scholars typically refer to it as the opposite of media trust and use the low end of a media trust instrument to measure it. Some scholars have questioned this approach and argued that media trust and distrust should instead be conceptualized and measured as distinct phenomena (Engelke et al., 2019). As a result, the nature of media distrust and its democratic implications remain unclear.

It is also worth questioning whether discourse on media (dis)trust alone can fully account for the growing animosity of contemporary audiences toward professional journalism. Extreme anti-media rhetoric is becoming a regular part of the public discourse globally (e.g., Fawzi, 2019; Meeks, 2020; Panievsky, 2021). Various reports also show that threats and attacks on journalists are increasing in many societies, including established democracies (e.g., European Centre for Press and Media Freedom, 2021; The Coalition for Women in Journalism, 2021). During the January 6 Capitol riot, the words "murder the media" were carved into a Capitol door (The New York Times, 2021).

These behaviors indicate that public animosity toward news media often takes a more extreme and intense form compared to distrust, which some scholars have described as media cynicism (e.g., Cappella and Jamieson, 1997; Markov and Min, 2021; Quiring et al., 2021). Cynical audiences believe that media actors are exclusively motivated by selfish interests and reduce media performance to the malicious intent of news producers. Cynicism is arguably a more detrimental perception compared to distrust because it "represents a distancing from the political process and, essentially, a closure to new information" (Pinkleton and Austin, 2004: 322). Therefore, previous research has called for future studies to investigate how media cynicism can be differentiated from distrust (see Vaccari and Chadwick, 2020).

The aim of this study was to explore how audiences describe their experiences of media distrust and cynicism, and how the two perceptions can be empirically distinguished. We report findings from 20 in-depth interviews conducted with news audiences in Serbia, a transitioning East European society that chronically holds its media in low regard (e.g., Pjesivac, 2017; Rugar et al., 2021). While the majority of research on media perceptions is set in established democracies (McLeod et al., 2017), this setting provides

important insights into media perceptions in a new democracy during a period of democratic backsliding.

Conceptualizing growing public animosity toward journalism

Distrust and declining media trust

As many recent articles note, a universally accepted definition of media trust does not exist (Fisher, 2016; Park et al., 2020; Quiring et al., 2021), but a general agreement is arising with respect to its most important elements (Fawzi et al., 2021). Audiences use news media to obtain information that will help them make informed decisions. However, many audiences do not have the resources to independently collect such information and/or to monitor various aspects of the news gathering process. Media trust is crucial to this relationship because it allows audiences to temporarily suspend uncertainty and engage with media based on positive expectations of media conduct.

Declining media trust has inconsistently (and often interchangeably) been referred to as low trust or a lack of trust, distrust,¹ as well as skepticism and cynicism (e.g., Ardèvol-Abreu and Gil De Zúñiga, 2017; Lee, 2010; Yamamoto et al., 2016). It is common for media trust studies to use the low end of a trust index to denote media distrust without explicitly defining it and its relationship with media trust. By so doing, these studies subscribe to the view that media trust and distrust are opposite ends of a continuum. Some trust theorists hold a similar view about the relationship between trust and distrust (e.g., Hardin, 2002; Schoorman et al., 2015).

In contrast, several communication scholars have adopted an alternative view and argued that media trust and distrust are related but distinct constructs (Engelke et al., 2019; Fletcher and Park, 2017; Park et al., 2020). This view commonly echoes Luhmann's claim that distrust is not only the opposite of trust, but also its *functional equivalent* in one's pursuit of reducing social complexity (Luhmann, 1979: 71). Trust performs this function by justifying the willingness to engage with the target on account of positive expectations regarding the target's conduct. Distrust performs the same function by justifying the unwillingness to engage based on negative expectations regarding the target's conduct. However, low trust (or no trust at all) does not necessarily mean actively distrusting the target. In the absence of information, a person can have both low trust and low distrust toward the target. Further, Lewicki et al. (1998) argued that distrust and trust can coexist because people form complex and multifaceted relationships that often involve diverse experiences with the target, which can result in contradictory expectations. Previous qualitative research has uncovered similarly nuanced and complex relationships between audiences and news media (e.g., Coleman et al., 2012; Schwarzenegger, 2020). Another study has argued that media trust and distrust do not necessarily share the same antecedents (Engelke et al., 2019). For instance, media trust can be based on familiarity with journalists, but unfamiliarity does not automatically lead to distrust. Therefore, our view is that media distrust is not necessarily the opposite of trust, but rather its functional equivalent.

Media distrust, skepticism, and cynicism

An influential definition illustrates a blurred conceptual boundary between media distrust and skepticism. Tsfati and Cappella (2003: 506) defined media skepticism as “a subjective feeling of mistrust” and “the perception that journalists are not fair and objective in their reports, that they do not always tell the whole story, and that they would sacrifice accuracy and precision for personal and commercial gains.” This definition does not clearly reflect characteristics that are often discussed as defining elements of skepticism, like ambiguity, reflexivity, and the need to monitor the environment. Skepticism has been described as “an attitude of reserve, where both trust and distrust are temporarily suspended” (Krouwel and Abts, 2007: 259) and skeptics as “people who may doubt words but are open to reason and willing to be convinced by deeds” (Kanter and Mirvis, 1989: 301). Following similar theoretical arguments, Quiring et al. (2021: 3499) provided a much-needed update of the definition of media skepticism as “a critical attitude that includes an awareness of the flaws of news reporting, but also a tolerance toward these flaws as long as they remain exceptions.” This definition helps clarify the difference between skepticism and distrust in the context of media perceptions. Distrust refers to a negative judgment relating to expected media performance regardless of how such a judgment has been reached. Skepticism describes a critical mode of engaging with the media—through doubt, constant questioning, and matching beliefs with evidence—and is less concerned with a resulting judgment.

Cynicism is contrasted as an attitude that lacks the nuance and reflexivity of skepticism, and instead represents a blanket rejection of the target. The concept of media cynicism was popularized by Cappella and Jamieson (1997), but scholars have only recently presented more focused attempts at defining and differentiating it from media distrust. Markov and Min (2021) defined media cynicism as a generalized animosity toward news media characterized by the belief that media actors are exclusively guided by self-serving interests and a definitive pessimism regarding the potential for a positive change in journalism. According to Quiring et al. (2021: 3500), media cynicism “refers to allegations that the whole media business is flawed and should result in a complete rejection of news as fabricated or severely distorted.”

Media distrust and cynicism in the (dis)information order

The review above suggests that more research is needed to address definitional inconsistencies and disentangle unclear relationships between the suggested constructs. In making our case for the importance of distinguishing media cynicism from media distrust, we follow a similar argument to Lewicki et al. (1998) and stress the importance of context when describing how actors relate. We argue that recent developments in media and political environments have significantly changed how some audiences relate to professional journalism, and that these changes necessitate a more nuanced understanding of negative media perceptions.

Bennett and Livingston (2018) discussed how audiences and journalists respond to the proliferation of fake news in order to illustrate the difference between an *established*

information order and an *emerging disinformation order*. The former is an environment in which journalism effectively performs its democratic functions through gatekeeping and professional practices. Accordingly, in a functioning information order, professional journalism can use gatekeeping and verification methods to debunk fake news and deflate attempts to spread it. The legitimacy of professional journalism when performing these functions is in large part rooted in public trust (Tong, 2018). Distrust protects audiences from potentially harmful coverage and provides feedback to the media to improve their performance. If the media are responsive, the expectation is that trust should recover (Pjesivac, 2017; Tsfati and Ariely, 2014).

While fake news once amounted to incidental disturbances in an established information order, Bennett and Livingston (2018) argue that this is not the case anymore. They describe an emerging disinformation order as a much more stable environment in which disinformation exist today. In this new order, professional journalism does not occupy a central position in the political information system as it once did. The gatekeeping function of professional journalism has subsequently weakened (Thurman et al., 2019). Political actors—both within and outside the mainstream—alternative news outlets, and influential individuals can reach wide audiences without journalistic mediation. This creates an opportunity for many actors to actively mislead the public and advance their own interests (Flew, 2019). They often demonize professional news media in order to delegitimize institutional journalism and position themselves as credible sources of information sources (Ladd and Podkul, 2019).

The disinformation order has not replaced the information order; the two coexist. Some audiences still rely on journalistic practices for selection and verification of information (Thurman et al., 2019). These audiences rely on reputable news organizations to fact-check and debunk fake news to help them make sense of increasingly complex information environments. Yet, other audiences see mainstream news media as a threat, so they turn to alternative sources and may even be open to outlandish information as long as it confirms their biases (Robinson and Holbert, 2018). Professional news outlets may engage in rigorous verification attempts to differentiate facts from falsehoods, but these audiences will not register such efforts as professional fact-checking. They are more likely to see such practices as further manipulation attempts, as a recent study shows (Brandtzaeg et al., 2018). To say that these audiences distrust professional journalism would not only be an understatement, but it may also be misleading. This is not a type of distrust (or skepticism) that is functional or open to correction if the other side improves its behavior. This kind of strongly fixed animosity irrespective of the target's conduct resembles cynicism – a perception rooted in the idea of the target's malicious intent, which becomes the primary lens through which a target is observed (Cappella and Jamieson, 1997; Dancey, 2012; Kanter and Mirvis, 1989; Markov and Min, 2021).

In conclusion, there is a growing need to acknowledge and reconceptualize the diversity of negative media perceptions. This will contribute to a more accurate diagnosis of the problem and more effective solutions tailored to specific grievances. In this study, we focus specifically on media distrust and cynicism. Media distrust is a widely studied concept that is not properly defined and is often conflated with different forms of public animosity toward journalism. Among suggested concepts, we see media cynicism as the

most undesirable perception that requires further examination and differentiation from distrust. Based on this review, two overarching questions that guided this study were: *How do audiences experience media distrust and/or cynicism? What do audiences' interpretive accounts suggest about differentiating media distrust from media cynicism?*

Method

Study context

The case of Serbia provides insight into the understudied context of audience perceptions during a period of democratic backsliding in a new democracy. In the first decade after the start of the democratic transition in 2000, some progress was made in Serbian media legislation with respect to EU standards. Despite this progress, problematic practices—including patronage networks, content tabloidization, and a lack of ownership transparency—prevailed and prevented the Serbian media system from achieving more substantial improvements in terms of journalistic professionalism (e.g., [Milutinović, 2017](#)). These existing problems in the media system were exacerbated by significant democratic backsliding in Serbia in recent years, which international observers like [Freedom House \(2021\)](#) describe as an example of a wider antidemocratic turn. A manifestation of this antidemocratic turn in the media sphere is a model of media capture in which the government uses formal and informal economic and political mechanisms to deflate critical reporting and amplify favorable coverage.

Procedure

Interviews were conducted in August and September 2020. Five interviews were conducted online and the remainder in person at locations chosen by the respondents. The average duration of the interviews was 79 min with a range of 53–101 min. Respondents received 500 RSD (approximately 5 USD) for participating in the study.

All interviews started with questions about the political interests and media habits of the respondents (e.g., “How do you usually follow the news,” “Are there any topics in the news that caught your attention recently”). These questions served to familiarize the respondent with the topic of discussion and to help the researcher identify the respondent's media habits. After that, the conversation moved naturally between different topics of interest for the study.

Discussion about evaluations of the media started early in the conversation. Participants were first asked how they would describe the news media scene in Serbia to someone who is not familiar with it. They were then asked about the criteria used to provide such classifications and were encouraged to provide deeper reflections on their opinions about the different groups of media they identified.

The final interview topic was intended to examine the expectations respondents have of good journalism. To better understand how participants in this study imagine desirable journalism, they were asked questions like “What do you expect of a good news report” or “What roles should the news media play in our society.”

Sampling and participants

The study utilized a purposive sample obtained through snowball sampling and employed two techniques to increase the diversity of the sample. First, sample seed diversity was maximized by recruiting three initial respondents who differ widely in age, gender, socioeconomic status, and political views. Each participant was asked to inform up to two acquaintances about the study and provide them with the researcher's contact information if they showed interest in participating. The second instrument for increasing the diversity of the sample was applied at this stage. Respondents were asked to recommend individuals with different attitudes about the news media compared to their own. In order to determine whether a potential participant would indeed increase the diversity of the sample, they were first asked to fill in a short questionnaire. The questionnaire contained items measuring attitudes toward the media and politics as well as questions about demographics. Based on this procedure, 20 participants were selected while three candidates were eliminated because the sample already included profiles very similar to theirs. Characteristics of the study participants are displayed in [Table 1](#).

Data analysis

All interviews were transcribed verbatim for analysis. The analysis followed the common framework for descriptive-interpretative qualitative research summarized by [Elliott and Timulak \(2005\)](#). During initial readings, the transcripts were inspected for meaning units in the data (i.e., the ideas expressed in responses that can independently provide some insight into the phenomenon of interest). Subsequent readings were conducted with more focused scrutiny of previously identified units consistent with the constant comparative method. In an iterative process, units were contrasted and compared in order to formulate themes that meaningfully converge. The priority was given to data, while the emerging patterns were compared to theoretical categories at the final stage of analysis.

Findings

As shown in [Table 2](#), the procedure outlined above resulted in identification of three categories of media perceptions that provide insight into how cynicism and distrust manifested in participants' accounts.

Perceived journalistic ideals and integrity

Democratic theories of journalism acknowledge both business and public service functions of contemporary journalism ([Schudson, 2003](#)). This uneasy cohabitation has inspired numerous professional, accountability, and ethical instruments to ensure that professional journalism does not lose sight of its democratic priorities (see [Bertrand, 2000](#)). Ultimately, a news outlet needs good business performance in order to provide high quality reporting in the public interest, but having good business performance does not guarantee that democratic ideals are met ([Schudson, 2003](#)).

Table 1. Characteristics of the sampled participants.

ID	Sex	Age	Region	Area	Education	Ideology	Political interest	Preferred party	Interview length	Interview method
P1	M	39	Vojvodina	Urban	University	3	4	Nonpartisan	90.49	Online
P2	F	66	Vojvodina	Urban	University	2	2	Nonpartisan	100.22	In person
P3	M	31	Vojvodina	Urban	Grad school	2	7	SZS	91.47	In person
P4	M	84	Center-West	Rural	University	6	5	SNS	75.37	In person
P5	F	74	Vojvodina	Rural	High school	6	4	SNS	79.56	In person
P6	M	39	South-East	Urban	High school	4	6	SZS	79.25	Online
P7	F	33	South-East	Urban	University	1	7	Nonpartisan	86.02	Online
P8	M	28	Belgrade	Urban	University	4	2	Nonpartisan	78.46	In person
P9	M	36	South-East	Rural	University	3	7	SZS	66.44	In person
P10	M	25	Vojvodina	Urban	University	4	3	Nonpartisan	73.51	In person
P11	F	36	South-East	Rural	High school	5	4	SNS	60.33	In person
P12	F	34	Belgrade	Urban	High school	6	6	Nonpartisan	78.28	Online
P13	F	47	Center-West	Urban	High school	5	3	No vote	75.27	In person
P14	M	47	Vojvodina	Rural	High school	4	7	Nonpartisan	95.07	Online
P15	M	52	Belgrade	Urban	High school	2	6	Nonpartisan	72.16	In person
P16	M	72	Vojvodina	Rural	High school	6	2	Nonpartisan	71.12	In person
P17	M	66	Vojvodina	Urban	University	2	5	Nonpartisan	101.26	In person
P18	F	43	Vojvodina	Urban	High school	4	4	SZS	53.49	In person
P19	F	56	Center-West	Rural	High school	5	3	SNS	81.16	In person
P20	F	25	Belgrade	Urban	High school	4	4	No vote	72.08	In person

Ideology was measured from 1 = left to 7 = right; political interest from 1 = not interested at all to 7 = extremely interested; preferred party was measured by asking for which party the respondent would vote if the election were tomorrow, SNS and SZS are the main ruling and opposition parties, respectively; interview length is given in minutes

Table 2. Differentiating media cynicism and distrust according to three categories of media perceptions.

	Journalistic ideals and integrity	Differentiation between media actors	Receptivity to journalistic performance
Media distrust	Probing; nuanced understanding of business and public service orientations	Moderate to high differentiation; various bases for differentiation	Outcome-oriented, somewhat receptive to performance countering negative expectations
Media cynicism	Deterministic; only business motives recognized, perceived lack of integrity	Low differentiation; animosity generalized across media actors	Process-oriented, unreceptive and dismissive of performance countering negative expectations

Distrust as a probing perception. In our study, distrust emerged as a more nuanced and probing perception. Uncertainty—that previous literature describes as a defining element of a (dis)trust relationship—was manifested in several responses as a tension between the competing functions of journalism. These respondents framed their expectations regarding journalistic conduct in terms of balancing normative values of journalism and business motives. Such considerations were reflected in P1 (male, 39, NGO manager, nonpartisan)’s nuanced description of expectations toward professional media:

(Professional media are) [t]he media that report objectively, that, on the one hand, respond to the needs of their target audience, do not deceive them, and on the other hand, balance it with the goals of their employers and owners, editors and so forth. They find balance between the interest of their employer—because they work for the profit—and, on the other hand, try to remain ethical as much as they can and inform objectively.

Because these participants perceived journalism as a balancing act between values and other priorities, they appeared motivated to monitor their media environments. Their media distrust reflects the belief that journalism is primarily a profit-making enterprise. However, they maintained that abiding to normative principles is possible and that it still constitutes an important criterion in their assessments of journalism. The same was the case when they discussed journalists; they commonly referred to individual integrity as a trait that can make or break trust, as P6 (male, 39, port worker, opposition supporter) explained:

A real journalist has a red line and knows how far they are willing to go, even if there are occasional departures and pressures... They know how to say – enough, I will not take it anymore, no matter the price, I am not going to lie, to write nonsense, to write something that

didn't happen, and always in favor of the same side. I think there are journalists who would never sell out, who understand journalism as their calling and believe in it.

Cynicism as a deterministic perception. In contrast, other participants did not appear to experience a similar kind of uncertainty towards the news media. They dismissed the notion of normative democratic functions of journalism altogether, not because they believed that journalists were failing at delivering these functions, but because they saw thinking in idealistic terms as naïve and irrelevant. These participants easily rejected even the mere possibility that journalistic work could be guided by anything other than seeking profit. This finding illustrates a deterministic property of cynicism, which is based on an a priori rejection of values and ideals as potential motives for the target's conduct (Kanter and Mirvis, 1989). P10 (male, 25, software developer, nonpartisan) exemplified this position by stating that "journalists do not care about the public interest because this is not what they are paid to do." Or, as P4 (male, 84, retired engineer, ruling party supporter) put it:

When you get money, you have to do as you are told. This was always the case and always will be – tie the donkey where the boss says. [...] It is the way your editor says – you can do this, you cannot do that, and we all know to whom the editor responds.

Several participants exhibited a strong inclination toward the assumption that other individuals lack integrity, consistent with previous literature on cynicism (Dancey, 2012; Rose, 2014). They expressed a view that journalists across the board are likely to use their competences for dishonorable purposes. As P17 (male, 66, mailman, nonpartisan) put it, "when the regime changes, chameleon journalists will cozy up to the new government en masse." Some discussed this perceived lack of integrity specifically in relation to journalists, like P4 (male, 84, retired engineer, government supporter), who expressed the belief that journalists use their agency in a decidedly sinister way:

Journalists are very corrupt. They can destroy a person, write something against a company and bury someone with their report. They know no one can do anything about it.

Others, however, related the perceived lack of integrity of journalists to the social circumstances that force journalists to make objectionable decisions. This view suggests the interconnection between media cynicism and generalized social cynicism. Participants who subscribed to this view made frequent references to injustice, inequality, and widespread corruption in describing Serbian society. They used phrases like "as we all do" or "just like everyone else" to stress that the lack of integrity is not confined to journalists but is representative of the entire society. P11 (female, 36, administrative assistant, ruling party supporter) stated that journalists are biased because "they have some personal interests, like everyone else, everywhere else," before adding, "I mean, I do not judge them." This is a form of more ambivalent media cynicism in which cynical beliefs appeared to be paired with understanding and empathy instead of resentment and contempt.

Differentiation between media actors

According to Krouwel and Abts (2007), one of the defining differences between distrust and cynicism is the amount of differentiation between object-related actors, which is significantly higher in the case of distrust. Our findings suggest that the rationales for differentiating media actors matter, particularly for understanding different modalities of distrust, i.e., active versus passive distrust.

Distrust based on moderate to high differentiation. Some participants were able to justify trusting or distrusting news outlets with reasons that were consistent with their beliefs in journalistic standards and values. For instance, P1 (male, 39, NGO manager, nonpartisan) named extreme bias and polarization as the biggest issues in Serbian journalism. He stated that he particularly distrusts *TV NI*² and *TV Pink*³ because the former “exclusively criticizes the government,” while the latter “exclusively criticizes the opposition.” P3 (male, 31, economist, opposition supporter) was well aware that his partisan and ideological preferences play a major role in his media diets. While he showed more trust in ideologically consistent outlets on average, he also provided reasons for both trusting and distrusting them. “They at least end their reports by saying that they tried to reach the other side for comments,” he stated, illustrating the perception of fairness as a reason for trust. He also added that “a journalist should not push me to one side without any evidence” while describing how a perceived lack of separation between facts and opinion is increasing his distrust toward the same group of outlets.

This type of active distrust is based on nuanced reasons that arose through participant elaboration. This is consistent with a perception described in previous research. According to Schwarzenegger (2020), *informed pragmatic trust* represents a decision to trust specific outlets in order to satisfy one’s need for orientation, while maintaining criticality about the flawed news production process. Very common for participants who exhibited active distrust was a strong feeling of self-efficacy and an emphasis on diversity in media diets when describing their news habits. This pattern is consistent with a strategy that previous research described as *reading between the lines* (Pjesivac et al., 2016), as illustrated by P6 (male, 39, port worker, opposition supporter):

You can never know who is 100% right. I know whom I trust more and whom I trust less, and then I take more media and some common sense to determine what is going on... It is not sufficient to simply follow both sides to know the truth.

For other participants, differentiating trusted from distrusted media actors was not clearly based on perceived adherence to professional standards. P8 (male, 28, court intern, nonpartisan) identified his reason for trusting the public broadcaster *RTS* as coming from a lifelong practice, saying, “we always watched the news on *RTS* in my house, ever since I was a kid.” P2 (female, 66, retired economist, nonpartisan) stated how it made her life easier to limit her exposure to only a few attitude-congruent outlets. “I need to trust someone”, she explained, “and I prefer listening to like-minded people.” These participants expressed a form of passive (dis)trust that is based on routines, familiarity, or

perceived similarity. They drastically limit their exposure to a few trusted sources and reduce the need to further monitor the media environment.

Cynicism based on low differentiation. In contrast, cynics generalize their conviction about the target's selfishness, malicious intent, and lack of integrity indiscriminately to all actors representing the object of perception (Krouwel and Abts, 2007). We consistently observed that more cynical participants in our sample recognized the same underlying mechanism operating in the entire field of journalism, rendering any distinction between media actors meaningless. Some of them expressed the view that all news outlets are equally susceptible to corruptive practices. P10 (male, 25, software developer, undecided voter) described this view by asking, "why would I believe that *NI* is not corrupt when all the others (other news outlets) are?". P14 (male, 47, farmer, nonpartisan) believed that the mainstream media only serve propaganda purposes, which is why he turns to alternative online sources for information:

The media in the 21st century use Gebbel's propaganda techniques to disseminate disinformation and manipulate the public. I distrust the media 99% of the time. I only use the internet, because the information flow is so fast online that it reduces the chances of censorship and manipulation.

As a result, media cynics do not see any meaningful difference between available news outlets, as P11 (female, 36, administrative worker, ruling party supporter) described:

In general, they (news outlets) are all the same to me, I don't see a big difference between them. The public television, private televisions, they all keep talking about one same thing. I don't know, maybe that's not a smart answer, but that's what I think – they all report the same way.

Receptivity to journalistic performance

Both cynicism and distrust entail negative expectations from journalism but differ in how they respond when their negative expectations are not met (Eisinger, 2000; Krouwel and Abts, 2007). Distrust is based on negative evaluations of previous conduct and is somewhat open to change in the presence of counter-evidence. Cynical evaluations focus on fixed views of media's self-interested motivation rather than on media performance. Cynical audiences are likely to discount counter-evidence and interpret it through the lens of their negative convictions about the target.

Participants' responses to one episode illustrate this point. In July 2020, president Vučić was interviewed about the country's response to the Covid-19 pandemic in a popular program aired live on the national public broadcasting service *RTS*. The episode caught the public's attention as president Vučić was demonstrably annoyed by the questions that journalist Olivera Jovičević had asked. The Independent Journalists Association of Serbia (NUNS) condemned Vučić's behavior, characterizing it as unworthy of the public function he performs, and asked him to apologize to the journalist and to the

people of Serbia. In the same press release, NUNS noted that Jovićević had tried to ask some critical questions in public interest.

Even though the study interviews took place approximately 2 months after the episode, it often emerged during the conversations with participants. Our interviewees who were generally strongly critical toward *RTS* diverged in their interpretations of the episode in line with expected differences between distrust and cynicism.

Distrust as an outcome-oriented perception. Our findings indicate that distrust is an outcome-oriented perception in which the focus is on the correspondence between the expected and observed performances. Distrusting participants evaluated the episode focusing primarily on the journalist's performance and the questions she asked. When their negative expectations were not confirmed, they were willing to acknowledge it. Their responses showed a degree of receptivity that indicates that exposure to professional conduct may reverse media distrust. "She probably had the information that what the president was saying was not true," mentioned P18 (female, 43, administrative assistant, opposition supporter), adding that "she was probably fed up with being silent." P17 (male, 66, mailman, nonpartisan) noted a positive shift in the journalistic approach compared to his usual experiences with journalists interviewing the president:

I was positively surprised in a sense that she tried to stand up and defend her dignity, albeit unsuccessfully, but at least she tried. Because whenever he (Vučić) shows up, journalists don't even try and just let him speak whatever he wants, or ask him questions as they were instructed.

Cynicism as a process-oriented perception. In contrast, other participants interpreted the episode in line with their preconceptions about journalism and press-media relationships, showing that cynicism is a more process-oriented perception. Even when they found some value in the questions that were asked in the program, they did not consider updating their beliefs based on the observed journalistic performance. Instead, they used it to reinforce their beliefs about the corrupt process that can only result in manipulative journalistic output. According to P9 (male, 36, lawyer, opposition supporter), the episode was meaningless and will only serve the public broadcaster to handle critics by saying "what about that one time when she (Jovićević) showed her teeth to the president?" P7 (female, 33, PR manager, nonpartisan) described the episode as "a performance" arranged by *RTS* and "ruthless professionals consulting the president" in order to convince the president's supporters that he is able to answer tough questions. Other participants shared a similar view, as illustrated by the following interview segment:

P10: It was all staged. I mean, those were all the questions that regular people would ask him [...] but it was all staged for him to appear fearless, able to stoically withstand answering every question [...] That's why that conversation was not sincere, it was fake... and it made me laugh.

Researcher: Why didn't you believe it was sincere?

P10: That was not the only time he was her guest; he was her guest a couple of times already. And, what, all of the sudden, she is asking him this kind of questions, being sarcastic, it doesn't seem plausible. I could be naïve, but no, frankly, it was all staged.

Conclusion

Both cynicism and distrust entail dissatisfaction with and negative expectations from news media. Our findings suggest that several properties can help differentiate them. We described cynicism as a deterministic and process-oriented perception that journalism serves no other purpose than to make profit, that no meaningful difference exists between news outlets in the market, and that journalists lack the integrity and agency to perform better. In contrast, distrust emerged as a more nuanced, probing, and outcome-oriented perception. Distrusting participants understood the financial pressures in journalism but believed that its main purpose is to complete important democratic functions. They also showed more receptivity to journalistic performances that did not conform to their negative expectations.

These findings have implications for the way scholars understand the current crisis in the audience-media relationship. Authoritarian political leaders and alternative news sources show a great understanding that public grievances about news media are rooted in a strong belief in the existence of malicious intent in professional journalism (Flew, 2019). Their criticisms, tailored to exploit this sentiment, continue to resonate strongly with large portions of news audiences. Typical instruments to measure media distrust cannot capture this sentiment and equate it with perceived lack of objectivity, balance, accuracy, or any other normative expectation (Robinson and Holbert, 2018). Cynical audiences will likely agree that the media are not fair and objective, but our findings indicate that these are not the key beliefs for identifying media cynicism. More important is the belief that the perceived negative performance is not a result of the media failing to complete their normative functions, but rather a result of the media succeeding in their true manipulative intent. Previous studies have recently proposed new instruments to capture such cynical beliefs about the media (e.g., Markov and Min, 2021; Quiring et al., 2021). Our findings can be used to further refine and increase the validity of these instruments by focusing on the characteristics of media cynicism identified in this study.

Equating distrust with cynicism also hinders the effectiveness of suggested solutions for improving media perceptions. Cynicism becomes the dominant lens through which audiences interpret all journalistic conduct, and cynical citizens are likely to discount professional reporting as another attempt to manipulate audiences. Emerging news literacy initiatives (see Tully et al., 2021) show the potential to combat such cynical media perceptions. Our study can help news literacy educators to differentiate cynical from distrusting audiences and emphasize different domains of news literacy that best address the nature of each negative perception. For instance, the focus of news literacy education for distrusting audiences should be on strengthening skills to actively monitor the media environment and make informed judgements when evaluating observed media performance. The goal is not to promote media trust at any cost, but to nurture a skeptical

perspective on the media, which could prevent accumulated distrust from turning to cynicism. In the case of cynical audiences, our findings suggest that the effectiveness of news literacy programs may depend mostly on the treatment of the media consumption domain. The goal should be to encourage cynical audiences to reflect on the role of their own biases in coloring (shaping) their media perceptions. This could be an important step toward reducing cynics' lack of receptivity to journalistic performance described in our study.

It is important to explore the possibility that our findings are limited to the Serbian context. It may be the case that Serbian audiences became cynical due to a long period of the media serving as the mouthpiece for oppressive regimes, and recent democratic backsliding and media capture. These factors have certainly contributed to extreme public animosity toward news media but they are by no means confined to a single country. In fact, they illustrate the trajectory of many new democracies in the region and beyond. It is also worth exploring whether media cynicism may have different characteristics from those we described in other contexts. For instance, participants in our study typically discussed financial—rather than political—aims as the ultimate motive of the perceived manipulative behavior of the media. They expressed the view that the media are entangled in the nexus of politics and business, and that the business side always takes precedence. Such a view may be reflective of Serbian citizens' long and turbulent history with economic transition. Cynical audiences in wealthier and more established democracies may perceive more independence between politics and business. They may attribute perceived manipulative attempts of the media to factors beyond profit-making, such as promoting specific political agenda. Qualitative and comparative studies are best suited to address this question in further research.

Additional limitations should be addressed and considered when interpreting these findings. This study was designed to explore nuances in negative media perceptions, but it was limited to describing the difference between cynicism and distrust specifically. Other forms of negativity, including skepticism, alienation, and nihilism should be explored in the context of media perceptions in future studies. Further, we did not analyze how media perceptions differ based on the interviewee's characteristics. Future studies should explore how our findings can be contextualized along the lines of age, gender, and political orientation of news audiences.

These limitations notwithstanding, our study provides an important step toward better addressing one of the biggest challenges of contemporary journalism: increasing public animosity. It provides a foundation to more precisely diagnose the problems in contemporary audience-media relationships and suggest effective solutions that promote more democracy-supporting media perceptions.

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Notes

1. Previous literature uses the term mistrust in addition to distrust, and recent review studies have addressed the relationship between the two terms. Engelke et al. (2019) consider them synonymous, while Fawzi et al. (2021) reference scholars who called for distinguishing them. However, this distinction is based on dictionary definitions and references to skepticism and cynicism, which additionally clouds the distinction between these concepts instead of clarifying it. Given the lack of theoretical reasons, it does not seem warranted to differentiate media mistrust and distrust. Instead, our focus should be on better conceptualizing media skepticism and cynicism, and explicating how these perceptions relate to media distrust.
2. *TV NI* is a regional cable news channel launched in 2014 as a *CNN* affiliate. While many respondents place it on the opposite pole from *TV Pink*, it is referred to inconsistently as a “pro-opposition” and “independent” outlet by government supporting and pro-opposition participants, respectively.
3. *TV Pink* was the most commonly cited example of an outlet with extreme pro-government bias.

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